1.4 Conflicts with Native Americans

When something that belongs to you is taken away, it can be difficult to keep the peace. Native Americans in the 1600s faced this challenge when colonists began to take over their ancestral lands.

MAIN IDEA Wars between Native Americans and Virginian colonists raged on and off for decades as each group laid claim to the land.

WARS WITH THE POWHATAN

For about eight years after John Rolfe and Pocahontas were married, the Jamestown colonists and the Powhatan lived in peace. During that time, the Powhatan helped the colonists plant corn, catch fish, and capture wild fowl. But as thousands of new colonists arrived to work for the Virginia Company, the Powhatan saw their land and culture taken away. In 1622, one Powhatan leader staged a rebellion against the English and their European and Christian customs. Colonists killed him, and the Powhatan responded by launching an attack on the colony, killing hundreds of settlers.

This attack set off a 10-year war. When peace finally came, it lasted for more than a decade. But even during the peaceful years, the colonists' desire for land continued to provoke the Powhatan. As the demand for tobacco as a cash crop increased, colonists, claiming the English king owned the colony and its land, simply grabbed land they deemed to be unoccupied. Although no one lived on the land, the Powhatan hunted, fished, and farmed on it. Two years later, the Powhatan attacked the colony again, triggering yet another war. In 1646, the Powhatan surrendered. Their leader was captured and later killed.

The two groups signed a treaty that required the Powhatan to live on lands north of the York River. They also had to make a yearly payment to the colonists of 20 beaver skins. The Powhatan had lost their power in Jamestown.

BACON'S REBELLION

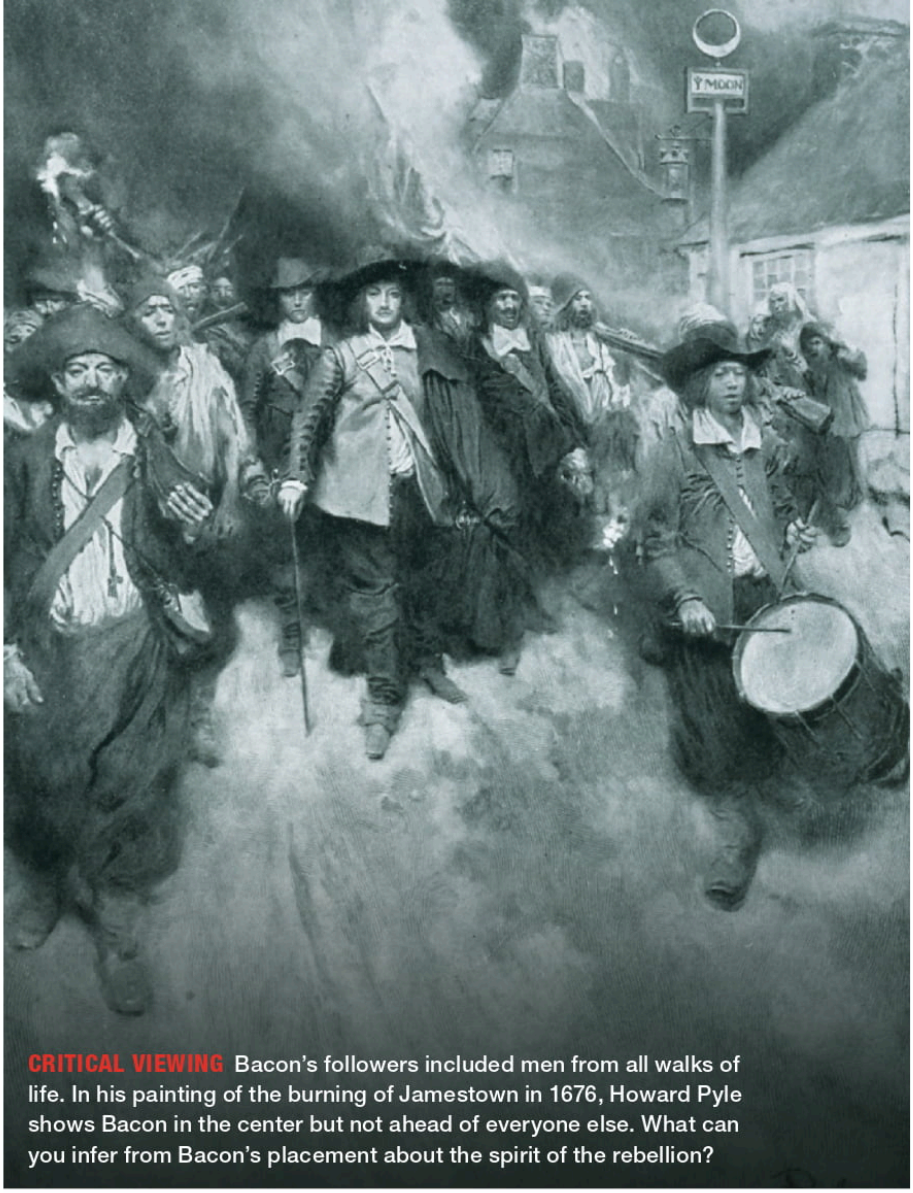
As years passed, conflicts between Native Americans and colonists increased. In the 1660s, the governor of Virginia, William Berkeley, urged colonists to interact peacefully and maintain trading to avoid a costly war. However, by 1670, tensions surfaced among colonists who owned land and those who did not. Landless freemen resented their lack of property and wanted a stronger voice in Virginia's government.



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Many of them had the right to purchase land, but low tobacco prices and high land prices made it difficult for them to find land they could afford to buy. They also claimed that the Powhatan controlled too much land, even though this land had been granted to the Native Americans by the 1646 treaty.

A young councilman and wealthy planter named Nathaniel Bacon, who was actually Berkeley's cousin by marriage, challenged Berkeley's leadership. He argued that the governor held too much power and that the colonists should be more involved with the government. He also wanted to claim more land from the Powhatan. Bacon and a group of landless followers attacked Native Americans in 1676 in an attempted revolution later called **Bacon's Rebellion**.



CRITICAL VIEWING Bacon's followers included men from all walks of life. In his painting of the burning of Jamestown in 1676, Howard Pyle shows Bacon in the center but not ahead of everyone else. What can you infer from Bacon's placement about the spirit of the rebellion?

Berkeley accused Bacon of being a **traitor**, or someone disloyal to his or her own people or cause, because he believed Bacon had challenged the power of the governor and his fellow wealthy planters. Bacon had growing public support, however. Bowing to this pressure, Berkeley agreed to be lenient with Bacon if he turned himself in and went to England to be tried before King Charles II. But the House of Burgesses did not approve of Berkeley's leniency. They forced Bacon to apologize to Berkeley. The power struggle between Bacon and Berkeley continued for several months. Bacon and his army even burned Jamestown to the ground in September 1676.

The rebellion ended a month later when Bacon died unexpectedly. Berkeley ordered Bacon's fellow leaders to be executed. Angered by these events, King Charles II demanded that Berkeley return to England. Some historians have interpreted Bacon's Rebellion as a fight against the authority of the local government, while others have described it as a power struggle between a powerful governor and a wealthy colonist. However, the Native Americans who were driven from their lands were ultimately the ones who lost the most.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the treaty of 1646 lead to Bacon's Rebellion?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** How does the map reflect Native American concerns about land?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did Nathaniel Bacon have public support for his rebellion?

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